

Historians and the 18th Century North American Colonies

"The French and Indian War, the American Revolution, and the Counterfactual Hypothesis: Reflections on Lawrence Henry Gipson and John Shy"

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Reviews in American History, Vol. 1, No. 3. (Sep., 1973), pp. 307-318.

The late Lawrence Henry Gipson was one of few American historians to erect counterfactual arguments into explicit research tools. Throughout his lengthy career he often repeated one major point: "that the American Revolution," as he put it in 1948, "was an aftermath of the Anglo-French conflict in the New World [between 1754 and 1763]. " Had Canada remained French after 1763, he asked, "would not Americans have continued to feel the need as in the past to rely for their safety and welfare upon British sea power and British land power, as well as upon British resources generally?" Britain's honest, rational, but expensive attempt to administer vast new territory acquired largely for the benefit of the older colonies clashed inevitably, Gipson believed, with their lessened sense of dependence. Britain had to ask them to accept in time of peace a series of impositions they had not felt even in time of war. The result was revolution, for despite the Empire's manifest needs, the colonies responded by demanding "greater autonomy than ever".

"No Awakening, No Revolution? More Counterfactual Speculations"

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Reviews in American History, Vol. 11, No. 2. (Jun., 1983), pp. 161-171.

At least since Herbert Levi Osgood proclaimed the Great Awakening as the first truly American event, historians have pondered its impact upon independence. Vernon L. Parrington saw it as a last explosion of clerical fanaticism from which the settlers happily escaped into saner preoccupations, such as the Revolution. John C. Miller linked it to class...Perry Miller tried to startle everyone by stressing the utter modernity of Jonathan Edwards; but his most distinguished student, Edmund S. Morgan, has emphasized quite a different contrast. He has juxtaposed the religious worldview of colonial spokesmen in 1740 against the astonishingly secular outlook of the Founding Fathers by 1790 and has tried to suggest how the Awakening helped to move America from the first position to the second.

With the Awakening gone, what can we now ask?

1) Would colonial resistance to British measures after 1763 have reached the point of armed rebellion by 1775? 2) If it had, would the Revolution have turned out differently with no Awakening to draw upon? 3) With no Awakening, would the republic of 1800 have been significantly different from the one we now love and study? The rest of this essay will suggest that we already know enough to provide clear answers to the first and third questions. Without the Awakening, colonial resistance would have taken very much the same forms it did and within the same chronology, but the America of 1800 would have been an unimaginably different place.